Polar molecules

In polar molecules, the centres of the positive and negative charges are separated even in the absence of an external electric field. They have a permanent dipole moment. Due to thermal motion, the direction of each dipole moment is oriented randomly (Figure 1.49(a)). Hence the net dipole moment is zero in the absence of an external electric field. Examples of polar molecules are H_2O, N_2O, HCl, NH_3.

When an external electric field is applied, the dipoles inside the material tend to align in the direction of the electric field. Hence a net dipole moment is induced in it. Then the dielectric is said to be polarized by an external electric field (Figure 1.49(b)).

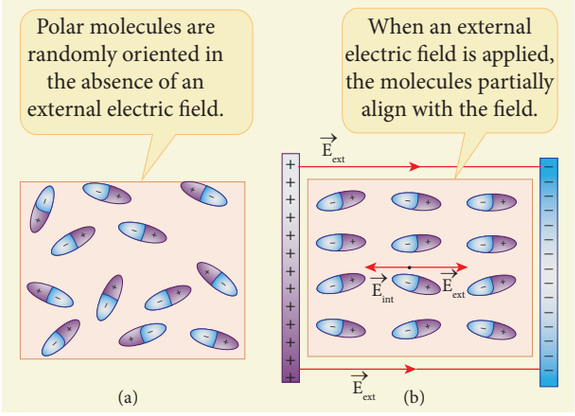


Figure 1.49 (a) Randomly oriented polar molecules (b) Align with the external electric field

Polarisation

In the presence of an external electric field, the dipole moment is induced in the dielectric material. **Polarisation $\vec{P}$ is defined as the total dipole moment per unit volume of the dielectric.** For most dielectrics (linear isotropic), the Polarisation is directly proportional to the strength of the external electric field. This is written as

$$\vec{P} = \chi_e \vec{E}_{ext} \qquad (1.80)$$

where χ_e is a constant called the electric susceptibility which is a characteristic of each dielectric.

1.7.5 Induced Electric field inside the dielectric

When an external electric field is applied on a conductor, the charges are aligned in such a way that an internal electric field is created which tends to cancel the external electric field. But in the case of a dielectric, which has no free electrons, the external electric field only realigns the charges so that an internal electric field is produced. The magnitude of the internal electric field is smaller than that of external electric field. Therefore the net electric field inside the dielectric is not zero but is parallel to an external electric field with magnitude less than that of the external electric field. For example, let us consider a rectangular dielectric slab placed between two oppositely charged plates (capacitor) as shown in the Figure 1.50.

The uniform electric field between the plates acts as an external electric field $\vec{E}_{ext}$ which polarizes the dielectric placed between plates. The positive charges are induced on one side surface and negative charges are induced on the other side of surface.

But inside the dielectric, the net charge is zero even in a small volume. So the dielectric in the external field is equivalent to two oppositely charged sheets with the surface charge densities $+\sigma_b$ and $-\sigma_b$. These charges are called bound charges. They are not free to move like free electrons in

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